

F-35 THE BIGGEST FAILURE IN AVIATION HISTORY?

The most expensive fighter ever produced, the F-35 JSF is supposed to be the star of the USAF. The pinnacle of US aircraft design, the ultimate fighter aircraft ever produced. In reality, the F-35 might be the most expensive failure in US aviation history. Born as a successor to the fabled F-22, the F-35 was designed to replace the entire fleets at the disposal of NATO armed forces. An aircraft that's supposed to satisfy the requirements of the army, air force and navy simultaneously.

Built to accommodate the needs of three different services and ideologies, the F-35 has grown to be nothing more than a massive compromise on all fronts. As it stands, the F-35 is a massive, heavy, lightly armoured, sparingly armed aircraft with limited range, a limited flight time, limited CAS abilities and inordinately expensive. The research funding has gone beyond the trillion dollar mark and for an aircraft that costs 10 times more than the ones it's all set to replace, it's doing a horrendous job. The previous generation aircraft, the F-15, F-16 and F-18 are all more than capable of out-matching the F-35 in most combat scenarios and while the F-35 is stealthy, that's all it has going for it. Oh, and did we mention that by some estimates, the F-35 needs to be serviced for 30 hours for every hour spent in the air?

The most advanced air-force in the world now has 200 seemingly useless stealth fighters, about 1400 conventional fighter aircraft that are at least three decades old and a bill that's running into the trillions with nothing to show for it.

So who's got the best aircraft? Europe and France would beg to differ, but without a doubt, that title has to go

to the Sukhoi Su-35. A mind-bogglingly agile aircraft with a staggering power to weight ratio that can render the wings obsolete. An aircraft that can loop-the-loop around an F-35 looping-the-loop, this Russian marvel can track 10 simultaneous targets and engage four (probably more) simultaneously, it can be equipped with the experimental KS-172 missile with a range in excess of a 100 miles and it's easily the most agile aircraft in the world. As an air superiority fighter, it's simply unmatched.



The most expensive fighter ever built?

BOMBING IS PASSE

Just to clarify, we mean large-scale bombing. It's long been known that carpet bombing, as a means of battering an enemy into submission isn't of much use against a determined opponent. Precision munitions against important targets are far more effective. It was in WWII that the British deemed it wise to carpet bomb the whole of Germany, it later turned out to be a futile effort that wasn't worth the expenditure in terms of cash and man-power both. The same

point was driven home in the Vietnam War as well, where the US dropped as many bombs on Vietnam (in terms of weight) as was dropped in the entirety of WWII. Both instances proved that while massive bombing campaigns might have some sort of psychological impact, the actual military value was not much.

Guided munitions are fast replacing dumb bombs and the fact that massive bombers such as the B-52 haven't been replaced in over 50 years are testament to that fact (and also the B-52's durability).

GUNSHIPS RULE

Close support aircraft have existed since WWII and since the time of the IL-76, it's been proven time and time again that a slow moving flying gun-carrier will do a better job providing fire support for troops than any type of fighter-bomber aircraft. Gunship development didn't really carry forward to the modern age for quite a while, but, necessity is the mother of invention and when US troops felt the need for some sort of real firepower on

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